

ACECQA Service Quality, Accessibility & Operations Analysis — Presentation Script

Target length: ~9:00, inside the assignment's hard 5–10 minute window. **[SHOW ...]** marks when to bring up each chart; keep your face visible in a corner the whole time per the assignment requirement.

Structure: one central business problem, three angles on it. Every section opens by naming the problem or question *before* the chart appears — the chart is evidence for a claim you've already made, not a pattern you're discovering out loud. If you only remember one thing from these delivery notes: never say "here's a chart showing X" — say "X is a problem, here's the proof" instead.

Opening — state the problem, not the topic (0:00–0:45)

[Face to camera, title slide]

"Hi, I'm [YOUR NAME], and I work for government to improve education and care services across Australia. Here's the problem I'm here to help solve: ACECQA and state governments have a limited budget for lifting service quality and funding new services, spread across seventeen thousand approved services nationally. Spent well, that budget closes real gaps for families. Spent on the wrong thing, it doesn't move the needle at all. So today I'm answering three questions with data: where is quality actually failing and why, where are families genuinely cut off from services, and — just as important — what should we *stop* assuming matters, so we don't waste money chasing it."

Data & method, briefly (0:45–1:10)

[SHOW a slide with the dataset summary, or talk over the title slide]

"Quickly on the data: this is the national register of every approved service, with quality ratings and transport-access data. Before trusting it, I checked it — ten services had no address at all and had all been geocoded to the same point in Myanmar. I dropped those rather than guess. Everything else checked out."

Problem 1: Is quality failing consistently, or is it a specific, fixable issue? (1:10–3:45)

"First problem: all eight states and territories apply the same National Law. If quality outcomes are wildly inconsistent anyway, that's either a resourcing gap or an enforcement gap — and knowing which one matters, because they need completely different fixes."

Chart 1 — Rating by state (1:20–1:55)

[SHOW 01_rating_by_state.png]

"They are wildly inconsistent. The ACT has forty-four percent of its services rated Exceeding NQS or above. Western Australia has four percent. Same law, ten-times difference. That's not noise — that's a finding that should already be uncomfortable for a national regulator."

Chart 2 — Rating by service type (1:55–2:15)

[SHOW 02_rating_by_service_type.png]

"It's not just geography. Long Day Care — the single largest category in the dataset — sits at eighteen percent Exceeding, well behind preschools at forty-six to fifty percent. If we're prioritising where a quality-improvement dollar does the most good, Long Day Care is where the volume is."

Chart 3 — Which Quality Area drags states down (2:15–2:50)

[SHOW 03_quality_area_heatmap.png]

"This chart deliberately asks a different question to Chart 1 — not 'who's excelling,' but 'who's actually failing to meet the legal standard.' And it splits the problem in two. The Northern Territory and Tasmania have the highest non-compliance rates — up to fourteen percent of their services rated Working Towards or Significant Improvement Required — concentrated in Quality Area 1, educational program, and Quality Area 7, governance. Western Australia, despite being worst in Chart 1, is actually a different problem: its services mostly clear the bar and sit at Meeting, they just rarely reach Exceeding. That's a ceiling problem, not a compliance one. NT and Tasmania have a compliance problem — real, and more urgent."

Chart 4 — Spatial map of ratings (2:45–3:00)

[SHOW 04_spatial_ratings_map.png]

"And it's local enough to act on directly — you can see clusters of underperforming services around Perth and Adelaide specifically, which means a support team could be deployed to a cluster, not spread across an entire state."

Chart 5 — Does distance from transport hurt quality? (3:00–3:45)

[SHOW 05_transport_vs_quality.png]

"Before recommending a fix, I need to test the obvious hypothesis: does poor transport access damage quality? I looked at the share of services rated below the NQS standard by distance to the nearest train station. It rises from seven-point-six percent for the closest services to ten-point-three for the furthest — real and significant, but small. A transport upgrade might nudge quality slightly; it won't close a ten-times state-level gap. A minor risk factor beside much bigger drivers."

Problem 2: Are families structurally cut off from services, and where worst? (3:45–5:50)

"Second problem, and I'm asking it the same direct way as Problem 1: not 'how far is transport' but 'does that distance push more services below the legal standard' — and does the answer depend on which state you're in? I classified every service into four ABS area types, spatially joined to its own coordinates, so I can grid non-compliance by state and by location together."

Chart 6 — Does distance from transport push more non-compliance? State by state. (3:55–4:20)

[SHOW 06_transport_by_urban_rural.png]

"Gridding non-compliance by state and by distance band: within most states it's flat. New South Wales, Victoria, Queensland sit within a couple of points of their own average no matter how far a service is from a station. What actually swings the number is which state you're in — Victoria around four to five percent everywhere, the Northern Territory up to twenty-six percent. Distance from transport is not the driver here. The jurisdiction is."

Chart 7 — Where does non-compliance concentrate: urban vs rural? State by state. (4:20–4:45)

[SHOW 07_rating_by_urban_rural.png]

"Same test, gridded by area type instead of raw distance — and this is where using all four ABS categories instead of a simple rural label earns its keep. Western Australia's small country towns: twenty-nine percent non-compliant. Queensland's: twenty-seven. Both far above those states' own overall averages. The Northern Territory's most rural areas are worst nationally, at thirty-one percent. A national rural/urban average would have buried every one of these."

Chart 8 — Spatial map, urban vs rural (4:45–5:00)

[SHOW 08_spatial_urban_rural.png]

"Mapping it shows how concentrated the whole system is — the vast majority of services sit in a thin coastal band, leaving a long, thin tail of small services covering the rest of the country."

Chart 9 — Does a bigger coverage gap actually predict non-compliance? (5:00–5:55)

[SHOW 09_coverage_gaps.png]

"Two questions in one chart. Left: where's the next service furthest away if a family's usual one is full? WA's smaller rural towns — a median forty-one kilometres, the biggest gap in the country. Right: does that gap actually predict non-compliance? Across twenty-seven state-area combinations, no — essentially zero correlation. Separate problems, separate fixes. Except one cell breaks the pattern: WA's Bounded Localities are bad on both — biggest coverage gap, twenty-nine percent non-compliant. One place, one investment, two problems solved."

Problem 3: Which operational factors actually drive quality — and which just look like they do? (5:55–8:15)

"Third problem, and it's a different kind of test. ACECQA could point to four operational levers — size, year-round operation, opening hours, how old a service is — and assume any of them explains quality. I tested all four directly. Two matter. Two don't."

Chart 10 — Does size predict quality? No. (5:58–6:18)

[SHOW 10_capacity_by_type.png]

"Capacity varies a lot by type and by area — sixty-six places typical in major cities, twenty-seven in small country towns. But tested directly against rating, the correlation is negligible. A bigger centre isn't a better- or worse-run one — useful for Problem 2: a new rural service doesn't need to match a city-sized centre to be a good one."

Chart 11 — Does year-round operation predict quality? Not independently. (6:18–6:40)

[SHOW 11_operating_pattern_by_type.png]

"Long Day Care runs almost entirely year-round and scored lower than preschools in Chart 2 — that could look hours-driven. But controlling for type, comparing year-round to term-time within Long Day Care only, there aren't enough term-time services to draw a conclusion. This is mostly standing in for service type, already covered — not an independent driver."

Chart 12 — Does approval date predict quality? Yes — the strongest signal here. (6:40–7:30)

[SHOW 12_approval_trend.png]

"A data trap first: approvals-per-year spikes in 2012 — over four thousand in one year. Read naively, that's explosive growth. It isn't — the National Quality Framework commenced that January and bulk-transferred every already-operating service onto new numbers, not newly opened ones. The right-hand panel is the real story: grouped by when they were actually approved, services from 2019 onward sit at just eight-point-six percent Exceeding or above, against twenty-two-point-eight percent for pre-2012, long-established services. Newer services simply haven't had the years of embedded practice yet. That's the strongest operational signal in this whole analysis."

Chart 13 — Does opening hours predict quality? Yes, modestly. (7:30–8:10)

[SHOW 13_hours_vs_quality.png]

"Opening hours does show a real relationship — thirty-seven percent Exceeding under forty-five hours a week, down to eighteen percent for the longest-opening services. Smaller than the approval-cohort effect, but real. And closing the loop on Problem 1: transport still doesn't move capacity or hours in any meaningful way — its small quality effect from Chart 5 stands on its own. Two of four operational levers actually drive quality; two are noise dressed up as insight."

Close — the decision, not a recap (8:10–8:50)

[Face to camera, optional summary slide]

"Back to the budget question I opened with. One: NT and Tasmania need urgent, statewide compliance intervention in educational program and governance — a legal-minimum problem, not a generic audit. WA is mostly fine broadly, a lower-urgency excellence-coaching fix, except its rural Bounded Localities, which hide their own compliance crisis inside a healthy state average. Two, and this connects directly: those same Bounded Localities are also the biggest coverage gap in the country — one place, two problems, one investment. Three: fund transport for equity, not as a quality play — real but small upside, don't oversell it. And four: give newly-approved services a support pathway, not a compliance one — they just haven't had the years yet. A budget with a reason behind every line. Thank you."

Delivery notes

- ~1,320 spoken words. At 140–160 words/minute that's roughly 8:15–9:25 — comfortable margin under the 10-minute hard cap even at a deliberate, unhurried pace. Practice once to check your own rate.

- **If you need to cut time**, in order: (1) the "Data & method" beat — compress the Myanmar catch to one sentence, (2) Chart 8's own beat — mention it in passing during Chart 9 instead, (3) Chart 11 — one sentence instead of two. Never cut Chart 5 or the transport call-back in Chart 13 — that "small effect, sized honestly against the bigger drivers" chain is your strongest evidence of analytical rigour for a policy audience, and it's what makes the closing recommendation credible rather than asserted.
- If asked why urban/rural wasn't done with the postcode-allocation method: the direct spatial join avoids the many-to-many postcode-to-SA1 mapping problem, since the dataset already has coordinates for every service.
- Keep the Family Day Care data-quality catches (capacity populated for only 2 of 417 services; "hours" meaning something structurally different for a scheme vs a single centre) in your back pocket for Q&A even if you don't narrate them in the timed script.